



THE INSTITUTE OF
MASTERS
of WINE

Chief Examiner's Report

2023 Stage 2 MW Exam

It is often asked whether it would be possible for the examiners to offer individual feedback on the exam. While it is not possible to comment on each candidate's exam scripts, there is a great deal of feedback in this year's examiners' reports that is highly relevant to those candidates whose marks fell below the pass mark. The examiners have unpicked in some detail the responses we received and have given carefully considered pointers towards what went wrong for many candidates, as well as identifying what went right. Please do study this all very carefully in order to elevate your study, understanding, and critical thinking abilities.

The candidates who passed this year's exam are to be congratulated. In total we have 17 candidates proceeding to Stage 3, the research paper. Notably, we had five clear passes in both the theory and practical exams, four of these being candidates sitting the exam for the first time. This is unusual in the recent history of the exam and I believe it is a sign that we are now seeing *some* better prepared candidates sitting the exam for the first time.

However, we saw a significant number of candidates whose papers across much of the exam were some distance from the pass mark (in the 50% to 60% range across all papers). While it was encouraging to see an even performance across all papers, a significant uplift in marks will now be required from these candidates to pass the exam convincingly. Do not underestimate the standard required across all papers for an overall pass mark.

I would encourage all candidates to be sure they have covered the entire scope of the syllabus in their studies before sitting the exam. In this year's theory exam there were a number of questions (e.g., Paper 1, Question 2; Paper 1, Question 4; Paper 2, Question 4) which were attempted by an extremely small number of candidates, with an even smaller number achieving successful results. This would suggest that candidates have gaps in their knowledge in certain areas of the syllabus. By limiting the breadth of your study, you may find yourself with a restricted choice of questions in the exam.

Examiners have frequently commented about knowledge demonstrated and examples used being commonly limited to the standard written references and seminar presentations. Where information has been gathered from wider sources, preferably at first hand, and with diverse viewpoints, a better perspective and greater depth of understanding may be achieved.

Candidates should always be aware that we live and work in a commercial world. Writing that demonstrates commercial awareness, where relevant, is always welcome. Answers with a complete disregard of financial issues will appear naïve and out of touch with the realities of the wine industry at all levels.

Neil Tully MW, Chief Examiner